



UNIVERSITY OF SAN JOSE - RECOLETOS
COMPUTER ENGINEERING DEPARTMENT



Seminars and Field Trips

Beyond the Day Job: How Engineering Side Quests Accelerated My Growth as a Software Engineer

May 23, 2026

Speakers:

Ray Earvin Palancos

Organizer:

John Genson

Harley Bacalso

Certificate of Participation



The seminar “Beyond the Day Job: How Engineering Side Quests Accelerated My Growth as a Software Engineer”, held on May 23, 2026, was presented by Ray Earvin Palancos. During the seminar, he shared his personal experiences as a software engineer and explained how doing “side quests” or extra projects outside of work helped him grow faster in his career.

One of the main ideas discussed was the importance of learning beyond formal education or regular job tasks. The speaker explained that while classroom learning and work experience are important, they are sometimes not enough to fully develop a person’s skills. He encouraged students to explore side projects such as building apps, contributing to open-source projects, and experimenting with new technologies. These activities help engineers gain practical experience and improve their problem-solving skills.

He also talked about how side projects help improve technical skills. According to him, working on personal projects allows engineers to practice coding, system design, debugging, and deployment in a more flexible environment. Unlike school assignments or work tasks, side projects give engineers freedom to try new ideas and learn from mistakes without strict limitations. This helps build confidence and deeper understanding of programming concepts.

Another important topic was career growth. The speaker explained that employers often look for engineers who are passionate and proactive. Having side projects in a portfolio shows initiative, creativity, and continuous learning. He shared that many career opportunities and promotions come from the skills and experience gained outside of the regular job. This makes side projects a strong advantage in the competitive tech industry.

Ray Earvin Palancos also emphasized the importance of consistency and discipline. He explained that doing side projects does not need to be complicated or expensive. What matters is being consistent and committed to learning. Even small projects, when done regularly, can lead to big improvements over time. He encouraged students to manage their time well so they can balance school, work, and personal development.

The seminar also highlighted the importance of curiosity and experimentation. The speaker explained that engineers should not be afraid to try new tools, frameworks, or technologies. Side projects give a safe space to explore and make mistakes, which is an important part of learning. He shared that many of his own skills came from experimenting with different technologies during his free time.

In conclusion, the seminar provided valuable insights into how engineers can grow faster through side projects and continuous learning. Ray Earvin Palancos showed that success in software engineering is not only about doing a job well but also about going beyond daily responsibilities. The seminar taught me that personal projects, curiosity, and consistency can greatly improve technical skills and career opportunities. It inspired me to take initiative in learning and to continuously build my skills outside the classroom.